A shared widget vocabulary, *many* layout shells.

mid-fi · engineering notebook · apr 2026

DESIGN THESIS

The engine already emits a structured fragment stream: `content`, `choice`, `dialog`, `media`, `kv`, `group`, `control`. Each client only needs to render these primitives — the *layout shell* above them is where personality lives. Bespoke per-world clients keep the primitive set and swap shells.

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§2 · SHELL.DOSSIER

Dossier split – primary focus

narrative mid, persistent sidebars

DOSSIER · LEFT RAIL

LEDGER	KV
step	4
cursor	request_help
scene	prologue
visited	2
met	1
flags	0

COMPANIONS & MET	BADGES
Aria	

LOCATIONS	BADGES
starting area	

KNOWLEDGE / FLAGS	BADGES
none	

fabula › **prologue** › **request_help** STEP 4

PROLOGUE / REQUEST_HELP

A guide's offer

IMG

ARIA

Aria's expression softens slightly. "The Northern Pass? Dangerous this time of year." She pauses. "But I know the way. For the right price, I could guide you."

CHOICES

1 Offer to split any treasure found →

2 Politely decline →

RIGHT RAIL

DECK (SPECULATIVE CCG)	CARD-VIEW

Rain on Oakomen · cost II

Aria's Compass relic · cost I

Fortress Rumor knowledge · cost —

HISTORY JOURNAL

#1 · prologue.start
↳ Approach the fireplace

#2 · prologue.meet_aria
↳ I'm looking for the Northern Pass

Dossier keeps the engine's structured sidecar data (kv, badges, item_list, table) visible across every step — matching what the CLI's `status` *shows.*

Keeps the engine's structured sidecar data (kv, badges, item_list) persistent across every step — matching what the CLI's `status` *shows. This is the shell I'd default bespoke worlds to.*

Sugarcube scroll — today's web client

text-forward, infinite history

crossroads-inn.storytangl.local / reader / scroll

tangl-web · shell.scroll

STEP 1 · PROLOGUE.START

The Crossroads Inn

The Crossroads Inn sits at the junction of three ancient roads. Rain patters against the windows as you push open the heavy oak door.

The common room is warm and inviting, lit by a crackling fireplace. A few patrons sit scattered at wooden tables.

↳ Approach the fireplace

Today's Vue client lives closest to this. Nothing wrong with it — but all the structured fragments (kv, badges, item_list) have nowhere to go unless we inject panels between blocks.

Stage + log

persistent scene, rolling journal

crossroads-inn.storytangl.local / reader / stage

tangl-web · shell.stage_log

STAGE · NO MEDIA

SCENE

PROLOGUE

A guide's offer

cursor · prologue.request_help

CHOICES

sh open the heavy oak door.... ↳ Approach the fireplace

↳ I'm looking for the Northern Pass

t I know the way. For the right price, I could guide you."...

1 Offer to split any treasure found →

2 Politely decline →

Media and current choices stay "on stage"; the log keeps a trimmed history. Good for worlds where media is the primary carrier.

Visual novel

full-bleed, dialog box, overlay choices

crossroads-inn.storytangl.local / reader / vn

tangl-web · shell.vn

NO BACKDROP · NARRATIVE_IM

1 Offer to split any treasure found →

2 Politely decline →

Aria

ARIA

Aria's expression softens slightly. "The Northern Pass? Dangerous this time of year." She pauses. "But I know the way. For the right price, I could guide you."

This is a natural target for the Ren'Py / Godot clients — the dialog box + sprite + backdrop maps straight onto those engines' idioms.

Card deck

where the Calvin-ball CCG could live

crossroads-inn.storytangl.local / reader / deck

tangl-web · shell.deck

STEP 4 · PROLOGUE.REQUEST_HELP

A guide's offer

IMG

ARIA

Aria's expression softens slightly. "The Northern Pass? Dangerous this time of year." She pauses. "But I know the way. For the right price, I could guide you."

1 Offer to split any treasure found →

2 Politely decline →

Each block is a card; swipe stacks into history. Good shell for the speculative CCG overlay — the narrative IS cards.

HAND	CARD-VIEW
Rain on Oak	omen · cost II
Aria's Compass	relic · cost I
Fortress Rumor	knowledge · cost —

STACK	2 PAST
#1 · prologue.start	
#2 · prologue.meet_aria	

Each block is a card; stack builds behind. Speculative hook: auto-built themed decks (high fantasy, steampunk…) emitted as card-view fragments alongside the narrative card.

Terminal – CLI parity

same fragments, different medium

tty · tangl-cli · derek@crossroads_inn

tangl-cli · shell.terminal

```
StoryTangl cli · ledger 7f3c…a81e · user derek
------------------
```

Rendering primitives in isolation

reuse everywhere, port verbatim

CHOICE LIST — PRIMITIVE

1 Approach the fireplace →

2 Talk to the innkeeper →

3 Climb the stairs — *needs key* ⊘

DIALOG LINE — PRIMITIVE

IMG

ARIA

"The Northern Pass? Dangerous this time of year."

?

INNKEEPER

"They say the old fortress holds treasure beyond measure."

MEDIA FRAME

PRIMITIVE

NARRATIVE_IM · TAVERN.SVG

PORTRAIT_IM

AVATAR_IM

KV · STATUS

PRIMITIVE

LEDGER	KV
step	3
cursor	prologue.meet_aria
scene	prologue
visited	3
met	1
flags	1

BADGES · ITEM_LIST

PRIMITIVE

COMPANIONS	BADGES
Aria Hound	

CARRIED	ITEM_LIST
Brass Key	relic · cost —
Old Map	paper · cost —

CARD-VIEW (SPECULATIVE)

FUTURE

II

OMEN C1

Rain on Oak

Reveal a companion at an inn.

I

RELIC C2

Aria's Compass

Shift the path one step safer.

—

KNOWLEDGE C3

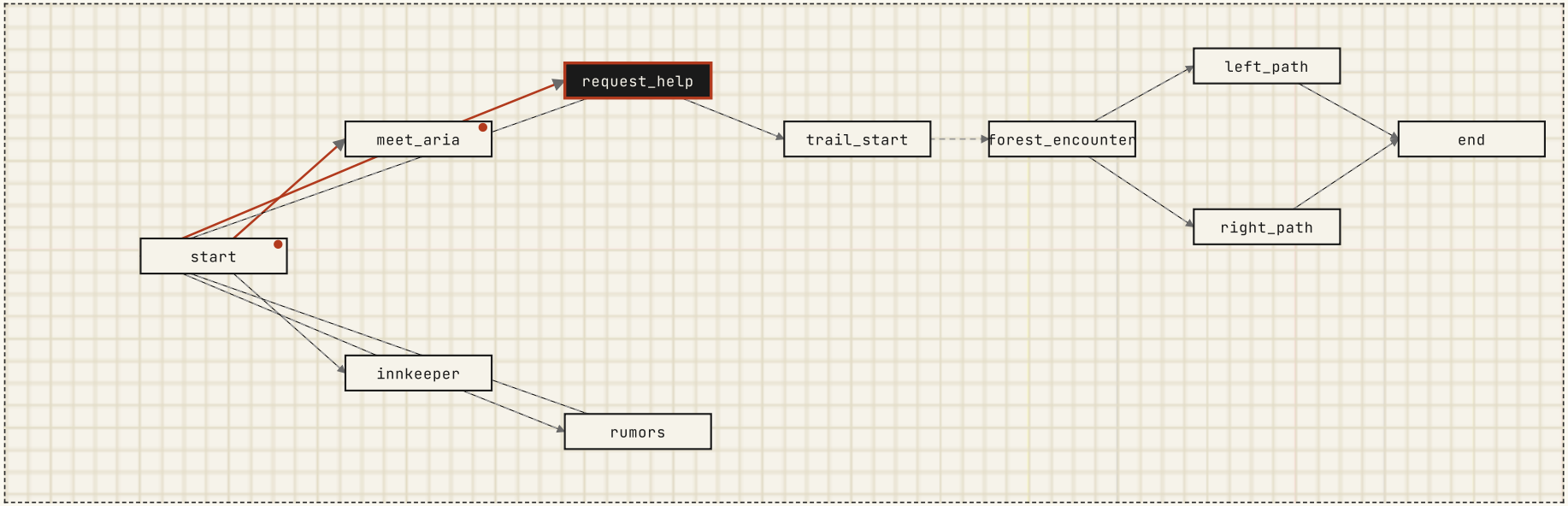
Fortress Rumor

Peek the next fork's risk.

§A · AUTHOR / DEBUG

Separate screen — graph, phase bus, fragments, ledger

not visible to the reader



nodes: 10 · edges: 14 · cursor: request_help

TEMPLATE LINEAGE	STORY

scene · prologue
block · request_help
compiled · StoryTemplateBundle@v38.3
authority · World("crossroads_inn")

PHASE BUS · CURRENT STEP

VALIDATE	PLANNING	PREREQS	UPDATE	JOURNAL	FINALIZE	POSTREQS	ADVANCE

follow_edge(→ request_help) · frame.step 4 · ledger 7f3c…a81e

EMITTED FRAGMENTS

```
[control] phase.enter JOURNAL
[dialog ] Aria Aria's expression softens slightly. "The Northern Pass? Dangerous this time of y…
[choice ] edge.1 Offer to split any treasure found → trail_start
[choice ] edge.2 Politely decline → start
[control] phase.exit JOURNAL
```

PROVISIONING RECEIPTS

```
[resolve ] Role(companion) → Actor(Aria) bound
[resolve ] Setting(inn) → Location(Crossroads Inn) bound
[offer ] Template(innkeeper) · rank 0.72 (not bound)
```

```
[fanout ] MenuBlock yielded 2 edges
```

Author view is its own screen — reader never sees this. But every widget here reuses the same primitives (kv, item_list, badges) as the reader's sidebars.

INSPECTOR · SELECTED

BLOCK.REQUEST_HELP — NODE

uid	prologue.request_help
kind	story.episode.Block
scene	prologue
speaker	Aria
media	—
visits	1
terminal	false

OUTGOING EDGES — ACTION[]

edge.1 → trail_start
"Offer to split any treasure found"
follow_edge

edge.2 → start
"Politely decline"
follow_edge

LEDGER JOURNAL — 3 STEPS

#1 prologue.start → Approach the fireplace
#2 prologue.meet_aria → I'm looking for the Northern Pass
#4 **prologue.request_help** · cursor

Everything here rides the same primitives as the reader: kv_list for block metadata, item_list for edges, badges for flags. A port to Qt/Godot mostly just reuses the Reader's widget library.

Phase-bus maps directly to VALIDATE → PLANNING → PREREQS → UPDATE → JOURNAL → FINALIZE → POSTREQS → advance. Handlers attach at phases; receipts stream live.